

OHSAA PLAYOFF BASKETBALL

Clippers upset by Heights



MORNING JOURNAL/JIM BOBEL
Clearview's Colin Watson, left, battles for a rebound in the second quarter of last night's Division III Elyria Sectional contest between the Clippers and Cuyahoga Heights. Clearview fell, 66-55.

By TODD SHAPIRO
tshapiro@MorningJournal.com
ELYRIA — In a night of upsets on the high school hardwood, the biggest upset of all took place in the Division III Elyria sectional, where unheralded Cuyahoga Heights stunned No. 2 seed Clearview 66-55.

The Redskins came into the game with a 10-11 record, the Clippers entered tournament play 16-4.

"Cuyahoga Heights just outplayed us tonight. They had the upper hand from the beginning of the game," Clearview coach John Szalay said. "We would not have beaten many teams the way we played tonight."

The Redskins jumped out to a 13-7 lead and the two teams traded baskets for much of the second quarter with Cuyahoga Heights taking a 26-24 lead into the halftime.

"I thought our kids really played with pulse tonight," said Redskins coach Mike Tartara in a jubilant post-game locker room. "I wish I could tell you how we did it tonight, sometimes with kids it's hard to know what to expect, but we worked hard and followed the game plan to perfection tonight."

The Clippers played much of the third quarter without 6-foot-3 senior forward James Washington who picked up his fourth foul just 2:30 into the second half.

Clearview appeared out of sync in the third quarter shooting just 2 of 11 and turning the ball over seven times.

"Of course the foul trouble hindered us as the game wore on," Szalay said. "But we're a no excuses basketball team."

The Clippers staged a frantic fourth-quarter comeback cutting the Cuyahoga Heights lead to six, 56-50, on a pair of Kyle Baugh-

man's 3-pointers. Baughman led the Clippers with 17 points in the game.

"I wouldn't expect that a lot of people in that guy gave us a chance of winning that game," Cuyahoga Heights forward Zach D'Orazio said. "Our league prepared us for Clearview's quickness and pressure defense. D'Orazio had 10 points and 11 rebounds for the Redskins."



Hitchens had 11 points before fouling out in the games closing seconds.

Tartara said winning the sectional championship had a special meaning for his team.

"Every game we've been wearing the marking 'RG' to honor Robert Garrett, the husband of former principle and current administrative director Lora Garrett who recently passed away," Tartara said. "They dedicated the season to him. While we've had a good season already, to come out and win the sectional championship for him is extra special."

The Redskins will play Lutheran West Tuesday evening in the district semi-finals.

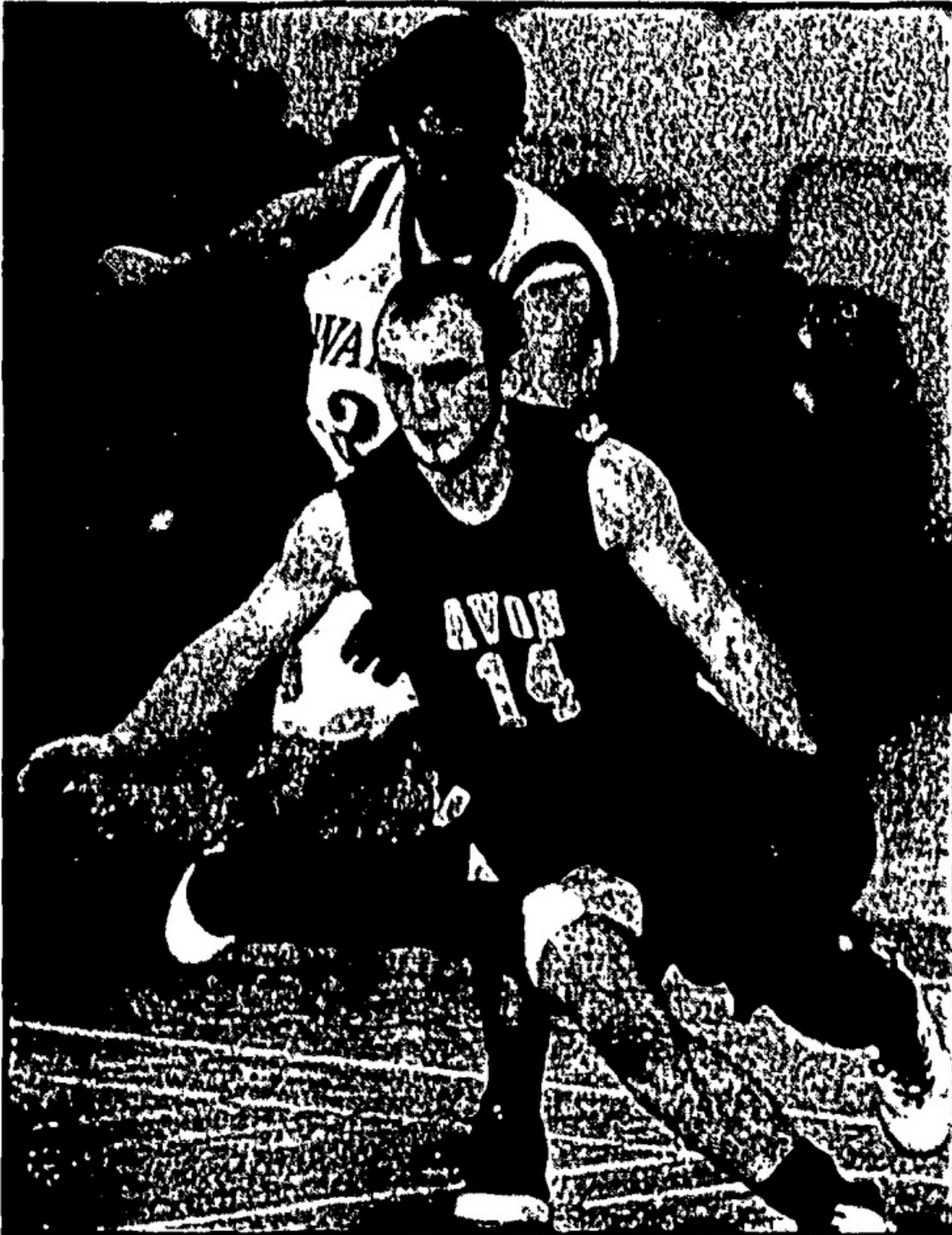
The Longhorns defeated Brooklyn 68-47 in last night's other sectional final.

Stephen Seton led Lutheran West with 18 points.

The Clippers, winners of 12 of their last 14 games, finished the season with a 16-5 record and a Patriot Athletic League Stripes Division championship.

"These kids had a good season," Szalay said. "Sometimes you just have one of these games, unfortunately ours came at the wrong time."

Eagles shrug off sluggish first half



MORNING JOURNAL/JIM BOBEL
Avon's Matt Logan, front, drives around Fairview's Marty Patton in the forth quarter. Avon went on to defeat Fairview 54-44 last night.

By MIKE PERRY
mperry@MorningJournal.com

WESTLAKE — Avon coach Jim Baker did not berate his team at halftime. He knew he didn't have to.

After his Eagles struggled to stop Fairview's interior offense, Avon righted the ship and cruised to a 54-44 win in the Division II sectional final at Westlake High School.

"We didn't come out with the intensity we needed," Baker said. "Maybe it was a let-down after we played Keystone, but we didn't do a good job on their post players in the first half. At half-time we talked about doing a better job in the paint and getting into our defensive sets a little quicker. We didn't yell or have a big scene in the locker room, we just stressed what we had to do."

"We have to defend the post because our game is to get out and run, and you can't do that if you don't make stops on defense." It didn't take long for the Eagles to respond to Baker's suggestions. Avon, after trailing 26-24 at the break, out-scored the Warriors 15-6 in the third quarter to establish a lead. In the fourth the Eagles put the game away.

"The Keystone game was a

big win for us," Baker said. "We were confident coming into this game, but that might have been part of the problem. Maybe we were a little too confident. We knew Fairview was a good match-up for us, but it took a little while for the kids to understand they weren't just going to give it to us."

"In the third quarter we woke up. We did a much better job defensively and did a better job taking care of the basketball and getting into our offense. We did a better job of finishing on both ends of the court."

Garrett Gronowski scored 12 points and pulled down 10 rebounds for Avon, who improved to 13-9 with the victory. They will now play Holy Name in the Westlake District Tournament semifinal Wednesday at 7 p.m.

"I think this was a good lesson for us," Baker said of his team's slow start. "I think the kids know, against Holy Name, if we come out like we did tonight, we could be in some trouble. We know we're going to have to play hard for 32 minutes if we hope to advance."

Both teams were able to take care of the basketball, each turning the ball over just seven times in the contest. Marquis Harrell paced Avon with a game-high 15 points.



NATE PARSONS MORNING JOURNAL
Keene Cockburn slams home a dunk against Westlake during first quarter action.

RANGERS

From Page C1

team could gain a foothold against the other. North Ridgeville held the Demons without a point over the final three minutes, but the Rangers couldn't take advantage themselves as they could only come up with two points on a pair of Cockburn free throws with 1:20 left in the first half.

No matter the combination on the floor for the Rangers, they couldn't shake the Demons through the third and deep into the fourth quarter as North Ridgeville led by a 36-34 margin with 2:45 left in the contest.

"I told the team that all we needed was a little 6-0 run to take control of the game," Noggle said. "That 3-pointer from Nick Rogerson was huge."

Noggle was referring to a 3-pointer that Rogerson drained with 2:15 left in the game. After a defensive rebound, Cockburn came down the floor scoring off a McGhee baseball pass to give the Rangers a 5-0 run and control of the game with their largest lead of the night at 41-34.

"Man that 3-pointer was big," Rogerson said. "We definitely needed that. My guy kept doubling on Drew (McGhee) and they kept leaving me wide open. I'm just glad I finally hit a shot."

Regina knocks off Panthers

By JAMES BRADY
jbrady@MorningJournal.com

WELLINGTON — After beating Columbus Thursday night to go to the girls Division III district final, what did Elyria Catholic earn for its victory?

The Panthers had to face Regina, the top-seeded team in the tourney and number one ranked team in Division III with an unblemished 22-0 record.

The final result reflected Regina's ranking as the Royals easily handled the Panthers, 72-38.

Regina captured its 11th straight district championship and advanced to the Cuyahoga Heights regional where it will face the winner of the Ashtabula district Wednesday at 6:15.

"This never gets old," Regina head coach Pat Diulis said. "Every year there is a different group of girls that have never gotten to experience this feeling. We have a high level of ability and a high level of expectations that go with it."

Instead of shying away from the Royals, the Panthers went right at them the best they could from start to finish. Elyria Catholic may not have had the big guns, but the heart and effort never left the floor.

"It's hard to see it end like this, but the girls were not intimidated and came out to give everything they had," EC head

coach Eric Rothgery said. "I told the girls to play hard and not to look at the scoreboard, that I would do that for them."

They pushed as hard as they could and never backed down. We probably lost to the best girls' team in Ohio, regardless of division."

Sophomore Emily Taylor did her best early on with five quick points, including a triple to keep the game close. But the Royals' Jackie Cook outdid her with 11 first-quarter points, including three straight three-balls, to give Regina a 18-9 lead at the end of the first.

Despite missing school on Friday because of the flu, Taylor finished as high scorer for the EC with 20 points, including a pair of triples. Sophomore Ashley Shoemaker was next in line with eight points and five rebounds.

Cook was one of four Royal players to reach double-figures as she scored a game-high 22 points. Taylor Mingo add 14 points, while Pa'onna Hope and Amber Boyd each netted 12 for Regina.

The Lady Panthers kept the game within shouting distance trailing 37-20 at the half, but the game slowly faded away in the second half as Regina took a 58-32 lead at the end of three and gave up just six points to Elyria Catholic in the final eight minutes of play.

Despite the loss, the Panthers future is quite bright as they lose just one senior, Kathrine McNeeley, from a team that finished the season at 16-8.

"This was a great experience and a lot of fun," said McNeeley about playing Regina. "I really didn't expect this kind of turnaround after the way we played my first two years (both 3-16 season). This was a special team and we never quit all season long."

Taylor spoke highly of her lone departing senior who will be attending Ohio State University next fall, studying Health Science.

"She was more than a mentor to me on the court," Taylor said of McNeeley. "If I needed help on or off the court, she was there to help me. I'm certainly going to miss her a lot over the next two years."

Despite the lopsided loss, there is an outside chance that the Panthers could suit up again next week.

Regina is the subject of an investigation by the OHSAA stemming from the Royals' second round win over Oberlin. If it's ruled that Regina did in fact use an ineligible player, the Lady Panthers could be awarded the district championship and advance to the Sweet 16.

When asked about the possibility of advancing despite the loss, coach Rothgery only had one piece of advice for his team in the locker room: "bring your uniform Monday in case we have to practice."

ADMIRALS

From Page C1

Scott Kimmey scored with 30 seconds left to give the Bulldogs the lead. Kimmey had a big fourth quarter, scoring eight of his game-high 28 points.

On the next possession Barnett found Parker in the corner for a 3-pointer. The Bulldogs quickly threw the ball down the court to John Atkinson who went in for the go-ahead, but Adrian Casey came out of nowhere to block the shot. Spencer Hawkins grabbed the loose ball and scored with less than 10 seconds remaining.

"I was just trying to stay focused and just focus on making the shot," said Hawkins about his go-ahead basket.

The Admirals had one last chance, but Kimmey stole the ball and finished the game off with a two-handed dunk.

"We believed the whole time we could play with them," Olmsted Falls coach Pat Donahue. "I had a feeling the game was going to be like this. When we went up by 16 points, I knew it wouldn't last."

The Bulldogs shot the lights out in the first quarter, taking a 23-12 lead. They finished the quarter 6 of 7 from the three point line, including a half-court buzzer beater from Colin Barth. Barth finished with three 3-pointers and 10 points in the opening quarter.

On the other, Casey picked up his second foul three minutes into the game and was forced to the bench. Casey battled foul troubles all game, finishing with just two points and five rebounds.

Stacey said it was difficult to watch his star player on the bench.

"As a coach you want your player out there," Stacey said. "He was frustrated, but you can't play a perfect game all year."

Barnett led the Admirals with 23 points, while Parker finished 13 points and Vincent Lee added 10 points.

Barth finished with four 3-pointers and 20 points, and Hawkins chipped in with 16 points.

In the end the Admirals fell short, but coach Stacey was proud of the way his guys represented themselves all season.

"This team hasn't quite all year," Stacey said. "I told the guys we did something nobody can take from you and that's a perfect regular season. We had one bad half all season, that isn't bad."



NATE PARSONS MORNING JOURNAL
Admiral King #3 Bryant Parker drives to the hoop and scores against Olmsted Falls.